

SHELL SHOCK A Bihar STF handout of the 2025 seizures triggered by the Mohania toll plaza raid in Kaimur

tion state for arms and ammunition smuggling networks. Besides the Haryana-UP corridor, parallel links were traced to arms dealers in Punjab, indicating a multi-state network. That's when Bihar Police called in the NIA, in August 2025.

Bihar kept up its front, meanwhile. In December, raids in Laheri, Nalanda, yielded 153 rounds of 7.62 mm AK-47 ammunition. The gang operated across the Jharkhand border. Five were arrested here—including Parvez Alam, an old offender—and four in Jamshedpur.

In February, an NIA supplementary chargesheet had a fifth name: Muzaffarpur native Manjoor Khan, arrested in August 2025, and said to have clients that included Maoists. An intriguing corridor feeding Bihar's ammunition market led to the Northeast: Dimapur in Nagaland. This came up after another Muzaffarpur arrest in 2024: two suspects, Vikash and Satyam Kumar, were nabbed at the railway station with a scope-fitted AK-47.

Takeaways

- **Recovery of huge caches of ammo creates alarm, NIA called in**
- **Inter-state links point to Haryana-UP corridor, even Nagaland connection**

THE GREY ZONE

As of last March, Bihar had 39,275 gun licence holders, each entitled to purchase 200 rounds of ammunition a year. This places nearly eight million cartridges a year within the formal supply chain. "Even a small percentage of leakage translates into thousands of rounds going stray," says an STF officer. If the catchment area extends to more of India's 3.4 million, the math is deadly.

The Arms Act has district magistrates as licensing authorities, with the onus of verification, renewal checks et al on the slender shoulders of local police. Licensed gun houses are to keep detailed sales registers. In practice, says a cop, "once ammunition leaves a licensed gun house, scrutiny weakens dramatically."

Why are bullets booming—as a business? A .315 bore cartridge is around Rs 180 when purchased legally, but sells for Rs 800 or more in Bihar's illegal market. A healthy mark-up for a low-risk enterprise compared to firearms trafficking. As for demand, that's one of the indices where Bihar doesn't lag behind. ■

RAJASTHAN

A Fake Forest Can Grow Fast

Rajasthan misses the trees... and the woods. Phoney 'plantations' replace shrinking forests

By **Rohit Parihar**

ON PAPER, INDIA PLANTS BILLIONS OF trees. On the ground, many of them are simply not there. A classic instance has come from Kota, Rajasthan, held up as Exhibit A in a stinging indictment by the National Green Tribunal (NGT). One failed plantation site may not paint the big picture, but it does present a bald X-ray of 'ground realities'. The Lakhawa I–VIII series of plantation sites were not short on ambition. Spread over 2,375 hectares, they seemed like rich compensation for 111.637 ha. of forest land lost to National Highway-27 over 2005-10 for a widening project. Problem was, field inspections exposed a sham: the original saplings had "entirely failed".

Other ecosystems likely flourish in its shade. Compensatory afforestation eats up thousands of crores, and Kota offers a snapshot of the quality of that expenditure. The National Highways Authority of India had given Rs 25.72 crore for Lakhawa's plantations, fencing and protection. Yet, a 2024 field inspection found "al-